

SCHOOL OF ELECTRONIC ENGINEERING AND
COMPUTER SCIENCE

MSC PROJECT STUDENT HANDBOOK

2025/26

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1 . I N T R O D U C T I O N

This handbook provides an overview of the MSc project modules within the School of Electronic Engineering and Computer Science.

All key information regarding the project process is here. It is important that you read the handbook thoroughly and follow the guidance provided.

The MSc project gives you an opportunity to apply the techniques and technologies that you have learned to a significant advanced project. This project will be an independent piece of work, which will either be significantly development-based or else have a research focus.

All projects will be expected either to investigate or to make use of techniques that are at the leading edge.

Please note that your project **must** be aligned with the learning outcomes of your programme of study e.g. MSc Data Science, MSc Artificial Intelligence, MSc Internet of Things and so on. A breakdown of your learning outcomes can be found under the headings: 'Academic Content', 'Disciplinary Skills' and 'Attributes' in the [Programme Specifications](#) for your specific degree.

The project will be supervised by an academic member of staff from a relevant research area that will culminate in writing a dissertation, which will be in the form of a conference/journal research paper. The paper will be evaluated using the standard criteria for scholarly work. In addition to a research paper, projects will also include a reflective essay and a viva component, where you will be required to demonstrate explain and defend your project.

1 . 1 A I M S

The MSc project aims:

- To give you the opportunity to investigate or apply leading edge techniques or theories in a significant, extended piece of project work.
- To enable you to gain a deep understanding of a specialised area of Electronic Engineering and Computer Science.

1 . 2 W H E N S H O U L D Y O U S T A R T ?

You will need to do some background reading in Semester 2 (Feb to March) as you are required to submit a project definition on **31st March 2026**.

2 . PROJECT SUPPORT

There will be a series of lectures delivered by the Project Coordinator to support you with your MSc project. There is also a dedicated QM+ module page where you can find the lecture slides along with other supporting material.

You are encouraged to use the forum on the QM+ page to ask any questions you might have. This will be monitored by the Project Coordinator who will answer questions and/or signpost you to where you can find useful information

NB: The forum is not a substitute for questions that your supervisor should be helping you with.

Your engagement with the project module will be monitored throughout the year. If we notice you are not attending supervision meetings, or there has been little or no engagement with the project work for some time, we will get in touch to check in with you.

If you are struggling with your project for any reason or are unsure where to go for help, please contact your supervisor or the Project Coordinator c.revell@qmul.ac.uk

3 . PROJECT SUPERVISION

3.1 SELECTING A SUPERVISOR

On **20th November 2025**, a list of supervisors and their project ideas/topics will be published on QM+. You should use this information to decide which member of staff you would like to contact to discuss your project ideas.

Procedure for supervisor selection and allocation

1. Read the supervisor profiles and project information on the QM+ page: *PG Project Supervisors*. Make sure you carefully consider all the information contained here before emailing a potential supervisor.
2. Before contacting a supervisor, download and complete the '*Initial Proposal Form*' from the QM+ page:
3. Complete the '*Supervisor Shortlist*' form. This needs to be completed before you start contacting any potential supervisors. The form allows you to select 5 academics who you are interested in being supervised by. **NB:** You are only allowed to contact the 5 people you have shortlisted. Academics will not respond to your emails if they do not appear on your 'Supervisor Shortlist'.
4. Contact the potential supervisor by emailing them with your completed '*Initial Proposal Form*'. It is important that when you contact academics that you demonstrate a keen interest and are well-informed about the potential project idea and/or the supervisor's areas of specialism.
5. As soon as you have an agreement with a supervisor, you must a) make all other potential supervisors you were communicating with aware that you will be supervised by another academic and b) stop contacting any further supervisors.
6. The deadline for supervision selection is **19th February 2026**. If you have not found a supervisor by this date you will be allocated one by the Project Coordinator by **27th February 2026**. Please be aware that these allocations cannot be guaranteed to align perfectly with your interests. Therefore, it is vital that you are proactive in finding a supervisor BEFORE the deadline.

Supervisors have a quota of project students, and the number of vacancies for taking on students will be updated online as students are claimed. Changing supervisors, once you have one, needs the agreement of your original and new supervisor.

3.3 KEEPING IN CONTACT WITH YOUR SUPERVISOR

It is important to meet with your supervisor regularly. Supervisors will have different preferences for how they want to conduct supervision meetings – either individually or as a group. The dates and times for these meetings should be agreed between you. If you have a particular issue that cannot be dealt with in a regular meeting, email your supervisor and ask for an additional appointment. Bear in mind

that academics have a busy schedule and sometimes may be away or unavailable due to other commitments. Do factor this into your project planning and try to be as flexible as possible.

Remember that your time with your supervisor is limited so to get the most out of the sessions you should:

- **Prepare.** It isn't helpful (for you or your supervisor) to just turn up to the meeting without having done any planning in advance. This is your project so think about what you want to get out of the meeting, what you wish to discuss and what specific advice or help you are looking for from your supervisor.
- Highlight any key issues/challenges.
- Inform the supervisor of any progress you have made since the previous meeting (where relevant).
- Make your own notes of what is discussed.
- Keep a project logbook/journal to keep track of your progress, your ideas, any challenges and what is discussed in your supervision meetings. Getting into the habit of doing this will help you to plan your work and the logbook will be a useful resource to look back on when you are writing your and preparing for your viva.

IMPORTANT: If your project is not going well, tell your supervisor about it. You should NOT stop going to meetings. Alternatively, if you think some general advice and support would be helpful, contact the Project Coordinator.

3.4 STUDENT RESPONSIBILITIES

- To monitor the project progress. Your role is essentially the project leader whereas the supervisor is more like a consultant and manager.
- To maintain regular contact and arrange appointments with your supervisor.

IMPORTANT: Remember that your project is marked by a supervisor *and* a second examiner. The second examiner may require further details regarding evidence of your implementation/practical work so will be relying on your supervisor to confirm this when it comes to the final assessment. If you have not maintained regular contact with your supervisor, both they and the second examiner will not be able to assess the quality of your work sufficiently.

- To be self-motivated and proactive. Your supervisor will not chase you up or do the work for you.

- To gain the knowledge required independently and deal with implementation details. It is not the responsibility of the supervisor to provide ready-made solutions. You should formulate any problems before asking your supervisor for help.
- To tell your supervisor about any equipment failure, technical or other difficulties, e.g. extenuating circumstances, that could have a detrimental impact on your work or deadlines.

If you are uncomfortable discussing any personal situations with your supervisor, please contact the Project Coordinator c.revell@qmul.ac.uk and/or the EECS Student Support Team via [AskQM](#).

- To respect academic staff time and to factor this into your planning and time management. You can expect to receive a response to emails from your supervisor or the Project Coordinator within **five working days** (this does not include weekends and holidays). If there is no response from your supervisor within this time, then please notify the Project Coordinator.

3.5 SUPERVISOR RESPONSIBILITIES

- It is the supervisor's responsibility to define the project objectives and the possible outcomes, or to refine these and check whether they are adequate if you have suggested your own project.
- The supervisor will provide advice and guidance but leave solutions and implementation details to the student.
- The supervisor will explain the project assessment method to the student and be responsible for evaluating the student's project in terms of quality and quantity of the effort expended.
- The project title and specification are a joint responsibility of the supervisor and student. The supervisor is responsible for providing feedback on your project definition and draft paper. Your supervisor will also be one of the assessors for the final deliverable of the project, which includes the dissertation paper and the viva (video and Q&A)
- Your supervisor is not obliged to chase you if you fail to keep appointments

4. PROJECT DELIVERABLES

4.1 WEIGHTING OF PROJECT ELEMENTS AND DEADLINES

The weightings and deadlines are as follows:

Project Element	Assessed by	Weighting	Deadline	Submission Location
Project definition	Not assessed but approved by supervisor	0%	31st March 2026	QM+
Draft dissertation research paper	Not assessed, however supervisor will provide feedback	0%	9th July 2026	QM+
Final dissertation research paper, reflective essay and supporting material	Supervisor and second examiner	100%	19 th Aug 2026	QM+
Presentation Video	Supervisor and second examiner		19 th Aug 2026	QM+
Viva Q&A*	Supervisor and second examiner		24th Aug to 11th Sept 2026	Location: Online

Key

Formative

Summative

*Failure to attend the viva will lead to a mark of zero for the project.

4.2 PROJECT DEFINITION

You are required to submit a project definition document on **31st March 2026**. This will be a 3–4-page description of your project. The contents of this document will vary depending on the type of project you are undertaking.

Your final achievements in your project will be judged against your project definition. It is possible to amend the definition during your project, but any changes must be agreed with your supervisor. You will also need to keep a record of any changes you make and the reasons for these.

Exactly what will appear in your project definition will vary with the nature of your project, but typically it will contain:

- Project Title
- Project Aims – this should be a broad statement of what you intend overall.

- Objectives – these will be more specific and measurable, relating to the expected outcomes of the project and presented in a list format typically starting with a verb e.g. ‘Investigate’, ‘Develop’, ‘Design’, ‘Identify’ and so on. There is no rule about how many objectives to include as this depends on what you consider to be appropriate.
- Details of the specific problem being addressed.
- An initial analysis of user requirements and data collection methods.
- The algorithms, methodologies, and techniques to be employed.
- An initial specification of how users will interact with the system.
- Programming languages, software, hardware, databases.
- A list of background materials consulted so far, including Internet resources.

Your project definition must be aligned with the learning outcomes of your degree. A breakdown of the learning outcomes can be found under the headings: ‘Academic Content’, ‘Disciplinary Skills’, and ‘Attributes’ in the Programme Specifications for your specific degree.

The document should also include a **project plan**.

Your project plan should break down the work you expect to carry out for your project into activities (tasks and sub-tasks) and estimate how long each will take considering whether one relies on the completion of another or can be carried out in parallel, etc.

The deadlines that you have for producing documents and the practical work/implementation should also appear on the plan. You can use a Gantt chart or any other project management tools of your choice or create your own, providing a list of activities and their start and end dates.

Your project definition *must* be agreed with your supervisor.

A pro forma is provided on QM+ for you to use to structure your project definition.

4.3 DISSERTATION - RESEARCH PAPER

Your project findings and results will be written up as a dissertation. This will be presented in the same format as a research paper that is submitted to an academic conference or journal. Your paper will be evaluated using the standard criteria for scholarly work. The submission deadline for your dissertation is 19th August 2026. This will be assessed by your supervisor and second examiner.

PLEASE DO NOT SUBMIT YOUR PAPER TO A PEER-REVIEWED JOURNAL/CONFERENCE OR ONLINE ARCHIVES WITHOUT SEEKING PERMISSION FROM YOUR SUPERVISOR.

Structure

The structure of your research paper will vary depending on the nature of the project. However, the basic structure will include:

Abstract

Introduction

Related work – *What others have done*

- Background research (primary research)
- and/or literature review (secondary research)

Methodology - *What you have done*

- Requirements capture / analysis – what your system should do
- Design – how you went about your work
- Implementation – practical techniques, problems, solutions
- Testing and/or evaluation – how well your solution worked

Results

Discussion / Conclusion

- This should be a critical analysis of your work and an honest appraisal of the achievements of your project.

Future work

- Discuss how your current work can be extended, which provides readers with an insight into new research directions.

References

Appendices

- This should include more detailed material that is relevant but not crucial to the understanding of the main message(s) of your project.
- If your project requires ethical approval, you should also include any documents relating to this in the appendices (see p.18 for more information on the ethical approval process).
- You must also include a statement acknowledging where and how you have used Generative AI tools in your project. A template for this will be provided for you to complete and upload.

4.3.1 PAPER FORMAT

- Two columns
- 8 pages for students on taught MSc programmes (including degree apprentices)
- 12 pages for students on MSc by Research programmes*

Please bear in mind the page limit for the paper as you progress. The format is based on what is expected for a paper that is submitted to an academic conference. Part of the skill of writing an academic paper is to be able to keep within the parameters you are given.

A template (LaTEX and Word) is available on QM+, which has the correct formatting required for submission. Please use these templates ONLY.

***MSc by Research Students**

Students on ECS755P, ECS754P or ECS753P (MSc by Research) are required to submit a 12-page dissertation (excluding references and appendices). The additional 4 pages should reflect more substantial results which translate into a more in-depth literature review, design, analyses and evaluation.

4.4 SUPPORTING MATERIAL

In addition to the dissertation you are required to submit files or a link to supporting material that relates your project work. This typically includes:

- Your source code, if applicable, but also any other material you would like to submit (e.g. completed questionnaires from experiments, component data sheets)
- A README file that acts as a guide to what files you are submitting
- An executable file of your software. If this is not possible, explain in the README file why and list the steps that the examiners would need to follow to run your code

4.5 REFLECTIVE ESSAY

You will also need to submit a 5-page reflective essay, which will supplement your research paper. The reflective essay is part of the making criteria for the project as a whole and is not assessed as an individual component.

The purpose of the essay is to allow you to elaborate further on the points below and include a reflective account of the project that would not normally be in a research paper.

- Analysis of strengths/weaknesses
- Presentation of possibilities for further work
- Work that you would have conducted if you had more time.
- Critical analysis of the relationship between theory and practical work produced
- Awareness of Legal, Social, Ethical and Sustainability issues.

The reflective essay has a submission deadline of 19th August 2026. The essay will be assessed by your supervisor and second examiner.

4.5.1 REFLECTIVE ESSAY FORMAT

- Font style: Arial
- Font size: 11
- Single line spacing
- Single column
- 5 pages max (excluding references)

A word template is available on QM+, which has the correct formatting required for submission.

Disclaimer

Please note: The project documentation you submit could be used as an exemplar for future students. These exemplars will be anonymous (i.e. we will remove any information that could make it possible to identify you). If you would like to opt out of this completely OR are happy for your name to remain in the paper (should people want to cite your work) please email the Project Coordinator.

4.6 DRAFT RESEARCH PAPER

You will have the opportunity to submit a draft version of your research paper on 9th July 2026 to your supervisor. This will not be assessed; however, you are strongly encouraged to do this as it is an opportunity for you to receive invaluable feedback on your work before the final submission of the paper.

4.7 PROJECT VIVA - VIDEO AND VIVA SESSION

The viva assessment will be split into two subcomponents:

- Project Presentation Video

- Viva Q&A Session

The viva will be assessed by your supervisor and second examiner. The viva is not marked separately from the dissertation paper and should not be treated as a separate component of the project. Both are taken into consideration before a final grade is decided. Please note that your performance in the viva can increase or decrease the overall mark gauged from the project documentation (dissertation and reflective essay).

4.7.1 PROJECT PRESENTATION VIDEO

Video is a powerful medium to disseminate your project as it gives you an opportunity to showcase your work to a wider audience and provide further insights.

You will need to create a 10-minute video (+/-10%), where you will be expected to provide an overview of your project and contributions. This is a unique opportunity for you to convince your examiners that your project is high quality and interesting.

The purpose of the video will be to provide an overview of the:

- area you worked in
- problem you focused on
- solution you designed and implemented.

The video is an opportunity for creativity, but this isn't its main purpose. It is important that you cover the following aspects of your work:

- the statement of the problem you investigated,
- the description of the methods used to solve the problem,
- a demonstration of your practical/implementation work,
- a summary of your work,
- a presentation of your results (both positive and negative).

IMPORTANT!

- You must appear on camera in the presentation video. A voice-over alone will not meet the requirements. If you fail to appear in the video your viva Q&A session cannot take place.
- Your video must be recorded at normal speed. Any videos speeded up to keep within the 10 min time limit will lose marks!

The deadline for the presentation video is 19th August 2026

4.7.2 VIVA Q&A SESSION

During the period 24th August to 11th September 2026 (excluding weekends and the bank holiday), you will be allocated a 20-minute timeslot for your viva where you will be assessed by your

supervisor and a second examiner on your ability to answer questions about your project. Questions will cover your contributions (i.e., methodology and demo), and the implementation/practical aspects (i.e., coding or experiments) of your project.

If you fail to attend the viva then you will receive a mark of zero for the project.

You will also fail your project if you fail to submit the Dissertation Research Paper, Reflective Essay, Supporting Documentation and the Presentation Video.

5 . C O N S T R U C T I N G A P R O B L E M D E F I N I T I O N

An excellent project depends on the construction of a clear problem definition. Stating the problem to be solved is more than just writing a series of anecdotal notes on the reasons that have motivated you to develop some hardware or write a particular piece of software.

Your initial thoughts on a topic may be: 'I have an interest in healthy living and wish to develop an application that supports users within the elderly community by providing them with intelligent recommendations to lead an independent and healthy lifestyle'. This would be a good starting point for a project, but it wouldn't be sufficient on its own. You will also need to conduct research to establish the specific areas of Electronic Engineering or Computer Science that relate to your topic area.

The method to investigate the underlying problem will require reading books, and research articles (e.g. papers from academic journals and conferences).

In relation to the healthy living example above, you would do the following:

- Read research articles on current software systems developed to encourage health and wellbeing within elderly communities.
- Investigate and review the range of functionalities they support.
- Identify issues and shortcomings.
- Investigate current software frameworks adopted to solve this problem.

It is essential that you have a clear idea of the underlying problem you are trying to solve, and you will only be able to demonstrate this through engaging with the existing literature.

The following resources are excellent starting points for your research.

- ACM Digital Library - <https://dl.acm.org>
- IEEE Xplore Digital Library - <http://ieeexplore.ieee.org/Xplore/home.jsp>
- Google Scholar - <https://scholar.google.co.uk>
- Computer Science Bibliography Database DBLP - <https://dblp.org/>

It is important that you create notes and summaries of the references that you find useful as these will inform your literature review which is a key component of your dissertation paper.

6 . R E S O U R C E S

6 . 1 H A R D W A R E

There is an area of the electronics laboratory for project hardware development, and you can request to be allocated a cupboard space in the lab to keep your hardware and work on your project.

The electronics lab provides a supply of basic electronic parts and you can take parts from the carousel in the 3rd floor electronics lab. For other specific parts you must request that an order form is created. The Lab Manager can authorise purchases up to £15, your supervisor up to £50 and above £50 the Project Coordinator must authorise. The total maximum budget per project is £100. Check whether we have parts already before you order anything, and we prefer that parts can be re-used. Any items purchased yourself cannot be reimbursed. The project remains property of QMUL and should be returned to the Lab upon completion of project.

Be careful about the package that integrated circuits use. Standard DIL packages are good for development on breadboard and strip board, but surface mount parts must have adequate adapters or fabrication of a suitable PCB must be considered before purchasing. If you need to have a PCB manufactured, also see the PCB technician to discuss complexity and lead times for manufacture. All purchasing and fabrications need to have been authorised appropriately before purchase or works are commenced.

All components not available in the carousel still need to be ordered, even if stocked.

For information on how to check for stock and to order hardware see [ElecLab: Project cupboards and order sheets | MyQMUL](#)

If you are using microcontrollers, check that we have access to a software development environment and programming capability for your chosen part.

Note: The project budget is only for hardware-based projects where you require electronic components to build a system. It cannot be used to purchase off-the-shelf products to be an add-on to your system.

6.1.1 GPU RESOURCES

If your project requires additional GPU, please contact comp-teach@qmul.ac.uk. Mention in your email that you are an MSc student, and you need this for your project work.

6 . 2 S O F T W A R E

Project students have access to the EECS Teaching Lab when no scheduled teaching is taking place (check lab timetables via your landing page). There may be times where you will still be able to access any unused machines during a scheduled lab but please be considerate of others and remember that teaching takes priority.

All the software you need should be available, but if you think you need something else, please consult the ITS team and your supervisor.

7. ETHICS AND PROJECTS THAT INVOLVE HUMAN PARTICIPANTS

The obvious ethical issues are fraud (e.g. passing off work that was done by someone else as your own) and plagiarism (which will be discussed further in Section 11). However, projects that involve human participants, e.g. user studies or experimental evaluations, also involve ethical issues. The principal issues are ensuring that participants have given informed consent and ensuring that personal details are protected in accordance with the Data Protection Act. The **EECS Devolved School Research Ethics Committee (DSREC)** has been created to review low-risk research involving human participants.

EECS DSREC's mandate is to contribute to a more efficient workflow for research ethics review at QMUL using a 3-layer approach

Layer 1: Does my research need ethical approval?

We have prepared a site with useful links and important information as to what be fully exempt from needing research ethics approval:

<https://qmulprod.sharepoint.com/sites/EECS-DevolvedSchoolResearchEthicsCommittee>

Layer 2: Local review of low-risk research

Ethical approval applications for 2025/26 MSc Project studies are invited from the start of Semester 2. However, you *must* discuss this with your supervisor prior to applying. Ethical approval needs to be in place *before* you start conducting any research involving human participants so it is important to allow adequate time for the application to be submitted and your request considered. Your supervisor will need to sign off the ethical approval application and should also be included in any emails you send to the EECS DSREC.

The *very* latest deadline to apply for ethical approval is: **SEM 2, June (following exams)**, *Exact date TBC*. Please note that you can - and ideally should - apply for ethical approval *prior* to the final deadline. Check the DSREC site above for the deadlines (these are usually monthly).

If you plan to undertake a low-risk research project involving human participants, you will need to complete our Online Individual Low-Risk Research Study Application Form:

<https://forms.office.com/r/5n2BBFPfvf>

This form has an initial filter, which will determine whether an application is low risk. If this is the case, then the applicant will be able to continue and submit their application via this form. Low-risk research projects will be reviewed by EECS DSREC.

Layer 3: QMERC review of medium and high-risk research

If your project is deemed medium or high risk, then our online form will prompt you to submit your application directly to the Queen Mary Ethics of Research Committee (QMERC). Medium and high-risk research studies will not be reviewed by EECS DSREC.

8. REFERENCING AND REFERENCING STYLES

8.1 REFERENCING

A crucial aspect of any academic writing is ensuring that it is properly referenced. This means that any sources, including Generative AI that have informed what you have written in your project work, must be acknowledged. These also need to be written correctly following a standard referencing system. The two main referencing systems are the Harvard and Vancouver styles. The Harvard system has the author's name and year appearing in the text, which links to a list at the end of the document. The Vancouver system has a number appearing in the text as a superscript or in brackets, which links to a list at the end of the document. The Faculty of Science and Engineering at QM requires students to use the **Harvard system ONLY**.

It takes practice to get referencing right so familiarize yourself with the Harvard system early on and keep a working bibliography and a list of citations as you go along. This will help you to avoid having to do this from scratch when writing your final paper and save you lots of time!

8.2 THE HARVARD SYSTEM

In the text

In his recent article, Leyden claimed that Google's new IM service has had a less-than-enthusiastic reception, "Early reaction to the service has been lukewarm." (Leyden 2005)

Reid and Dunlop (2003) stated that...

Beymer et al (2005) stated that... (3 or more authors)

Fig. 1. Audio classification framework (Divakaran 2004, p.29)

Web references

Leyden, J. (2005) Google Talks Up IM Service. *The Register* [on-line]. Available from http://theregister.co.uk/2005/08/24/google_talk/ [Accessed 7 November 2014]

Department of Health (2006). *Fluoridation of drinking water* [online]. Available at: <http://www.dh.gov.uk/assetRoot/04/13/60/15/04136015.pdf> [accessed 13/9/2006].

Book reference

Naisbitt, J. (1984). *Megatrends*. New York: Warner Books.

Periodical (journal) reference

Raikkonen, K., Pesonen, A.K., Jarvenpaa, A.L. & Strandberg, T. E. (2004). Sweet babies: chocolate consumption during pregnancy and infant temperament at six months. *Early Human Development*, 76 (2), 139-145.

Conference proceedings reference

Beymer, D., Russell, D. and Orton, P. (2005) Wide vs. Narrow Paragraphs: An Eye Tracking Analysis. In: Costabile, M.F. and Paternò, F. eds. Human- Computer Interaction – *INTERACT 2005. Proceedings of the Tenth IFIP TC13 International Conference*, LNCS. Vol. 3585. pp. 758 - 792. Heidelberg: Springer-Verlag.

Referencing Generative Artificial Intelligence – see section 11.2 below on referencing the use of Gen AI in your work.

More information on referencing can be found on the Queen Mary Academic Skills [Referencing Hub](#)

9. PLAGIARISM, GENERATIVE AI AND ACADEMIC MISCONDUCT

9.1 PLAGIARISM

Plagiarism effectively means presenting the work of others without stating where it has come from (sourcing), or to put it simply, trying to pass off someone else's work as your own. Queen Mary defines 'plagiarism' as:

*"...presenting someone else's work as one's own, irrespective of intention. Close paraphrasing; copying from the work of another person, including another student; using the ideas of another person without proper acknowledgement; and repeating work that you have previously submitted – at Queen Mary or at another institution – without properly referencing yourself (known as 'self-plagiarism') also constitute plagiarism. Unfortunately, including material without proper acknowledgement has become far too common and QMUL takes a **very firm line** on any such offences."* [**Queen Mary Academic Misconduct Policy**](#)

It is your responsibility to ensure that you understand what plagiarism is and what you can do to avoid it.

9.2 USING GENERATIVE AI TOOLS IN YOUR PROJECT

As part of your project, you will be expected to produce both project documentation and practical work, which includes (but is not limited to) hardware/software implementation, practical experiments, and simulations. Given the increasing use of Generative AI, there are many questions you will have on your mind, such as *Can I use AI tools for my project? Can I use it for my literature search? Can I use it to write my code?*

It is important to know that *any* content submitted as an assignment, whether text, images, code or anything else, should *not* be the product of a tool or a piece of software in the same way as it should not be the work of another person as in cases of plagiarism. This also applies when you use software for translating work you have written in another language into English.

"Unauthorised or unacknowledged text manipulation which undermines the integrity of an assessment (including the use of paraphrasing software, generative artificial intelligence or machine translation such that the work submitted cannot be considered wholly the student's own)." [**Queen Mary Academic Misconduct Policy**](#)

When and how can I use AI for my project?

You can use AI tools to help you understand a challenging concept by generating a plain English explanation or providing examples. You can also use it to explore the general ideas about a topic to identify search terms and keywords for your search strategy using the library database, IEEE Xplore, ACM Digital library and Google Scholar.

Are there any limitations?

Yes, Generative AI can create 'hallucinations' or fake data or information that is convincing but not based on reality. Furthermore, it can produce fake references or citations, which could lead to academic misconduct. If you are using AI tools, you need to take a critical approach and ask yourself the following questions about the output:

- Is generated output accurate?
- What are the gaps, inconsistencies, or irrelevant pieces of information?
- What happens if you ask the question again – look at similarities, differences and patterns in the outputs and think about what they could tell you.

Don't just rely on whatever is generated by an AI tool, as they cannot access the most current information from sources such as the Queen Mary Library database, IEEE Xplore, ACM Digital Library and Google Scholar.

Do I need to reference where I have used Gen AI?

Yes! It is important to explain where you got your information from. The University has put together a guide on how to reference AI within the Library Services [Referencing Hub](#) including information on how to do this using different referencing styles such as Harvard.

Can I avoid using it?

As AI continues to be integrated into search engines, everyday software, and tools like ChatGPT and Microsoft CoPilot, it is becoming increasingly challenging to avoid using AI entirely. AI in a broader sense has already been here for a long time, with features such as predictive text, and it is likely that more tools will incorporate generative AI so seamlessly that you may not realise you're using it. Be cautious.

IMP: Remember that you will be asked to complete a statement acknowledging where and how you have used Gen AI in your project work so keep detailed notes of what you are doing as you go along.

For further information on using AI in your studies see the following QM resources:

[Student Guide to Generative AI](#)

[AI for Student Learning and Research](#) – online course

9.3 ACADEMIC MISCONDUCT PROCESS

If you are suspected of academic misconduct, you will be reported to the Academic Registrar for an examination offence under the QMUL *Regulations for Assessment Offences*. Under these Regulations, students found to have committed an offence may have their whole diet of assessments invalidated or be expelled from the College.

A range of methods, including special software tools such as TurnItIn are used to detect plagiarism, and project papers are routinely put through an electronic plagiarism detection system. Your project

examiners will also question you during the Viva Q&A to determine if the work you have produced in your project is your own.

Before uploading any assignments remember to always ask yourself the fundamental question:

Am I sure that what I am submitting is my own work?

10. PROJECT MARKING POLICY

Project marking policy for postgraduate projects:

- The pass mark for the project is 50%.
- The final dissertation paper and viva are worth 100% of the project mark, which is assessed by two examiners (supervisor and second examiner).
- When there is a discrepancy of 10% or less between the marks of both examiners then the average is taken as the final mark unless marks span pass/fail.
- When there is a discrepancy of 10% or less between the marks of both examiners and the marks span the pass/fail borderline, then both examiners will discuss for agreement, if no agreement is reached then the project will be assessed by a third examiner.
- When there is a discrepancy of greater than 10% between the marks of both examiners but is within the same grade i.e. Distinction or Fail, then the average is taken as the final mark.
- When there is a discrepancy of greater than 10% between the marks of both examiners, across different grades then both examiners discuss for agreement, if no agreement is reached then the project will be assessed by a third examiner.
- Normally the third examiner's mark remains within the original two examiner marks.

11. RESITTING A PROJECT

Resit projects follow separate procedures - you will receive information by email. You are entitled to feedback on your previous attempt and on your revised draft paper from your supervisor (or another appropriate member of staff, if your supervisor is not available). Assessment is by dissertation paper, viva presentation video and viva Q&A.

The overall mark for projects passed at a resit is capped at the minimum pass mark of 50%.

12. PROJECT SESSIONS, ACTIVITIES AND DEADLINES

Semester	Week Commencing	Online Sessions	Activities	Project Deliverables and Submission Deadlines
1	27 th Oct 2025	Introduction to the MSc Project- Date TBC		
1	10 th Nov 2025	Supervisor Project Pitch - Date TBC		
1	17 th Nov 2025		Supervisor Selection Process Opens 20 th Nov 2025	
2	16 th Feb 2026		Supervisor Selection Process Closes 19 th Feb 2026	
2	23 rd Feb 2026		Supervisor Allocation Complete -27th Feb 2026	
2	2 nd March 2026	Project Definition and Research Methods – Date TBC		
2	16 th March 2026	Literature Review and Plagiarism –Date TBC		
1	30 th March 2026	Information Literacy – Date TBC		Project Definition and Plan 31 st March 2026
3	8 th June 2026	Project Deliverables – Date TBC		
3	6 th July 2026			Draft Dissertation Paper 9th July 2026
3	18 th Aug 2026			Dissertation Paper and Reflective Essay 19 th August 2026
3	18 th Aug 2026			Presentation Video Submission 19th August 2026
3	24 th Aug 2026 31 st Aug 2026 7 th Sept 2026			Viva Schedule 24 th August to 11 th September 2026

APPENDIX

APPENDIX A - MARKING SCHEMES

MSC MARKING SCHEME – DISSERTATION PAPER, REFLECTIVE ESSAY AND VIVA

	%	0 – 49% Poor	50-59% Satisfactory	60-69% Good	70-79% Very Good	80-89% Excellent	90-100% Outstanding
PROBLEM DEFINITION, BACKGROUND, LITERATURE REVIEW, AIM AND OBJECTIVES • Clarity of problem definition • Project aligned with programme of study • Critical analysis of the literature, which leads to new insights • Critical awareness of current problems • Demonstration of established research techniques to create and interpret knowledge • Clarity of the project aims • Clarity and relevance of project objectives <i>Determined by dissertation paper and viva</i>	25	The problem is not substantial for a master's project. The dissertation has an adequate overview of a few relevant papers with no critical analysis or new insights. The student has not defined the aims and objectives of the project. Project is not aligned with the learning outcomes of the student's programme of study	The problem definition has very little substance, as it is informed by anecdotal experiences, as opposed to research. The dissertation has a satisfactory review of relevant papers with limited critical analysis. The student has partially demonstrated established research techniques to create and interpret knowledge. Limited awareness of current problems. The student has defined the aims of the project, however the objectives are vague.	The problem definition is informed by research. The student has also defined a series of research questions. The dissertation has a review of relevant papers with some critical analysis, but no new insights. The student has demonstrated established research techniques to create and interpret knowledge. There is awareness of current problems, with limited critical analysis. The student has clearly articulated the aims of the project, with a series of relevant objectives.	Meets the 'Good' criteria and the following: Very good, concise review of relevant papers with critical analysis, relevant to the context of the project. This also includes a few new insights. Objectives clearly support the project aims.	Meets the 'Very Good' criteria and the following: Excellent literature review with a concise critical review relevant to the context of the project, which also identifies gaps in knowledge and new insights.	Meets the 'Excellent' criteria and the following: Evidence of extra-curricular academic reading, critical thinking and original interpretation.

	%	0 – 49% Poor	50-59% Satisfactory	60-69% Good	70-79% Very Good	80-89% Excellent	90-100% Outstanding
ACHIEVEMENT • Achievement of aims and objectives • Use of advanced methodologies, tools and techniques • Understanding and application of the concepts relevant to the discipline • Evidence of advanced problem-solving skills • Originality in tackling and solving problems • Quality of output/solution (including creativity and innovation – forefront of the specialisation) <i>Determined by dissertation paper and viva</i>	30	The student failed to achieve the aims and objectives of the project. The student did not use advanced methodologies, tools and techniques. There is no evidence of use of problem-solving skills. The student has not produced sufficient deliverables. Quality and completeness of work is poor.	The student has partially achieved the aims and objectives of the project. The student has provided limited evidence of advanced methodologies and tools for the practical element for this project. Some evidence of problem-solving skills, but they are not advanced for the level of study or founded on solid and sound discipline knowledge. Evidence of effort, but implementation may be only partially functional. Lack of originality in solving the problem.	The student has provided clear evidence of achieving the aims and objectives of the project. The practical element is good; however, it lacks rigour and has not been implemented correctly. Evidence of advanced problem-solving skills.	Meets the 'Good' criteria and the following: The student has adopted a sound methodology to solve the project problem. Advanced problem-solving skills steeped in discipline knowledge are demonstrated throughout the project. Achievement not substantial enough to warrant top mark, e.g. it may contain some ambiguities or faults. Student has demonstrated originality in solving the problem.	The student has adopted a rigorous methodology to solve the project problem. Advanced problem-solving skills used both within and outside student's core discipline or skillset (developed by the degree program). The student has produced a considerable output in terms of creativity and innovation. There may be some minor faults in execution or understanding.	Meets the 'Excellent' criteria and the following: Project objectives have been exceeded. The project demonstrates depth of conceptual thinking and methodological rigour. The project has made a contribution to the field.

	%	0 – 49% Poor	50-59% Satisfactory	60-69% Good	70-79% Very Good	80-89% Excellent	90-100% Outstanding
QUALITY OF WRITING/DISSERTATION - Clarity of ideas - Style – technical precise, concise and formal wording - Logic – reasoning - Flow – the purpose of each section is clear. The links between and within sections are established - Communicate conclusions to specialist and non-specialist audiences. - Quality of figures and legends - Correct referencing <i>Determined by dissertation paper</i>	14	The write-up is unclear or written badly. It is very difficult to understand core ideas. The write-up is disorganised. Figures and figure legends are of insufficient quality. There is no referencing/ done incorrectly.	The write-up is somewhat incoherent, rushed, contains important omissions, or irrelevant material. Figures and figure legends are of satisfactory quality. Referencing is satisfactory, but incomplete for some claims or sections.	Adequate write-up, lacking clarity or detail in places, or containing irrelevant material. Good use of technical language. Figures and figure legends are of good quality, as they are helpful for understanding the project. It is easy to understand the core ideas. Referencing supports claims well, is used well, and uses consistent format throughout.	Clear write-up with logical structure and good flow. Precise, technical, formal style. Figures and figure legends are of very good quality. Graphs are clear, fully annotated, easy to read and used appropriately to support claims. Referencing is good and follows a standard consistently.	Very good write-up with a logical structure, good flow, technically precise and concise style. Figures demonstrate conceptual thinking; graphs are fully annotated, are easy to read and interpret, provide insight, and fully support claims and conclusions; figure legends are concise and informative. Referencing is employed throughout and follows the prevailing or recommended discipline standard.	All criteria for “excellent” met. Only very minor faults in execution, depth of understanding or write-up. Close to faultless in execution and write-up.

	%	0 – 49% Poor	50-59% Satisfactory	60-69% Good	70-79% Very Good	80-89% Excellent	90-100% Outstanding
EVALUATION, TESTING AND ANALYSIS - Adequacy and rigour of testing - Quality of the documentation of testing - Critical analysis of results - Analysis of strengths/weaknesses - Presentation of possibilities for further work - Critical analysis of the relationship between theory and practical work produced - Awareness of Legal, Social Ethical Issues and Sustainability - Critical evaluation of the project process Determined by dissertation paper, reflective essay and viva	16	For implementation-based projects, testing is insufficient or poorly designed, so that it does not support the claims.	For implementation-based projects, testing is attempted but is not complete or has design flaws. Testing documentation lacks detail or is incomplete.	For implementation-based projects, testing may be designed and planned well, but it is not comprehensive, or it may lack rigour. Not all requirements are fully verified by testing.	For implementation-based projects, testing verifies majority of requirements using rigorous and well-documented procedures with only minor flaws.	For implementation-based projects, there is evidence of thorough and flawless testing.	For implementation-based projects, there is comprehensive testing. Analysis of strengths & weaknesses are present.
		For a research-based project, there is no critical analysis of the results. Weaknesses and improvements are not considered.	For a research-based project , the critical analysis of the results is trivial. Weaknesses are only partially identified.	For a research-based project , critical analysis of results is presented but may lack rigour or may present some reasoning flaws. Weaknesses and improvements have partially been considered, but some gaps remain.	For a research-based project , there is evidence of critical analysis of results. Weaknesses and improvements have been considered to some depth.	For a research-based project , there is critical analysis of the results. Weaknesses and improvements have been fully thought out with well-supported arguments.	Documentation is outstanding (includes details to allow replication).
		For both types of projects, critical analysis is not attempted.	For both types of projects, the evaluation is limited, e.g. it is primarily based on informal observations, or the results do not fully bear out the conclusions.	For both types of projects, the evaluation lacks rigour in execution and reasoning.	For both types of projects, documentation provides the detail that enables scrutiny and replication of tests.	For both types of projects, the evaluation provides an evidence-based critical analysis of the project, drawing strongly on deep discipline knowledge.	For a research-based project, there is critical analysis of methods and results. Weaknesses and possible extensions are argued well and offer further interest in the topic.
		Documentation is poor.	Documentation is patchy; it provides information but not insight. Description of procedures lack detail. Result tables do not support drawing of conclusions.	Documentation enables replication of tests. Tables are used appropriately to document test conditions and results and support drawing of conclusions.	For both type of projects, the student adopted rigorous evaluation process and the results fully support conclusions.	Documentation is detailed, methodical, rigorous, and clear, enabling replication of tests and proper scrutiny of results.	Documentation is outstanding (includes details to allow replication).
		There is no reference to the legal, social and ethical issues and sustainability.	There is a very brief reference to the legal, social and ethical issues and sustainability.	There is awareness of the legal, social and ethical issues and sustainability, but complex issues are not explored.	There is awareness of the legal, social and ethical issues and sustainability that goes beyond the obvious or the trivial.	There is a clear awareness of the legal, social and ethical issues and sustainability, with some complex issues teased out.	There is a very clear awareness of the legal, social and ethical issues and sustainability.

	%	0 – 49% Poor	50-59% Satisfactory	60-69% Good	70-79% Very Good	80-89% Excellent	90-100% Outstanding
DIFFICULTY LEVEL AND AMBITION Considering the student's prior knowledge: - Level of difficulty of the project in terms of understanding and implementation - Demonstrates self-direction in planning and implementing project tasks at a professional level Determined by dissertation paper, reflective essay and viva	10	Level of difficulty is insufficient. E.g. the project may have replicated existing work without adding contribution, or execution is trivial for the level of study within the student's core discipline. The student has produced very limited or incomplete deliverables (code, hardware, paper). No evidence of troubleshooting or seeking workarounds when problems were encountered.	The level of difficulty is basic and satisfactory. The project produced a working solution with only basic functionality. Novelty and contribution are minor or trivial. Some evidence of troubleshooting or seeking workarounds when problems were encountered.	Project not particularly ambitious, however the student has implemented a good project or a working solution to the problem. Evidence of resourcefulness: the student proactively sought alternative routes to solving issues in the project. Evidence of good troubleshooting skills.	The challenge that was set was met with correct and confident application of the scientific or engineering methods. Evidence of resourcefulness: Student proactively sought alternative routes to solving issues in the project. Evidence of good troubleshooting skills. Evidence of critical thinking in all stages of the project, including when tackling unforeseen difficulties.	Meets the 'Very Good' criteria and the following: The student has produced a considerable body of deliverables in terms of both software/hardware and write-up. Excellent troubleshooting skills. Evidence of lateral thinking and proactive engagement with challenges.	Meets the 'Excellent' criteria and the following: Challenging goals, and substantial deliverables, which have the potential to inform further development or study (e.g. publication).

	%	
VIVA PRESENTATION VIDEO AND Q&A SESSION	5	- Quality of Video – organisation, presentation and does not exceed the maximum time of 10 minutes (+/- 10%). - Videos must be recorded at normal speed. Any that are speeded up to keep within the 10-minute timeframe will lose marks. - Contribution - The video highlights the contribution that this project makes. - Ability to answer questions - synthesis and ability to defend - Confidence in answering questions related to the practical/implementation (i.e., code) aspect of the project - Demonstration of knowledge and understanding